



ZOOM

A cloud-based video conferencing service,

Zoom quickly became one of the most preferred video calling services during the COVID-19 pandemic for schools and offices. The best part about Zoom is the tiled view which allows you to see tens of participants on the screen simultaneously.



START SCREEN SHARING

Sharing your screen for meetings or even to watch movies together with your friends can be quite useful. The best thing about Zoom is that they haven't tucked this nifty function deep within the menus. In fact, all you need to do is click the Share Screen icon on the toolbar at the bottom of the meeting screen. You can then choose to share your entire desktop or just one window. Simply hitting Alt+S on your keyboard will also activate screen sharing on Zoom.



SET UP VIRTUAL BACKGROUNDS

Zoom also has the ability to apply a slew of virtual backgrounds, replacing your bland, dull backgrounds in video calls. The feature can be used just for the fun of it or can even be used by executives in companies to apply their company's logo in the background. On the desktop app, click on your profile in the top right corner and then navigate to Settings. Here, on the menu to the left-hand side, click on Virtual Background. Zoom provides a few default background options which you can apply by simply clicking on them. If you want to upload your own custom background



An example of a Zoom virtual background

simply click on the '+' icon on the Virtual Background page and upload a photo from your PC. On the mobile app, when you join a meeting tap the three dots on the bottom right of the screen and open the 'More' menu. Tap Virtual Background and select a default option or upload your own.



SET UP BREAKOUT ROOMS

This tip is especially useful for larger groups in video calls. Breakout rooms in Zoom allow the creation of smaller rooms within one all-encompassing video call. For instance, if there's a company working on a new issue of a magazine, one breakout room can be created for the editorial team to discuss stories and writing assignments, one room can be created for the marketing team, one for the finance and so on. Up to 50 breakout rooms can be simultaneously running on Zoom. The host can even pre-assign attendees to specific rooms. You can do this by going to Settings, under the Meeting tab enable the Breakout Room option. Now, the host can access Breakout Rooms in their video conferencing menu. The host can also jump between these rooms. *Note: This is a paid feature.*



RECORD AND TRANSCRIBE YOUR CALLS

If you're subscribed to the advanced Zoom plan with cloud recording, you can record your meeting's audio to the cloud. The AI built into Zoom will also transcribe these meetings along with timestamps as well. The transcript file will be saved as a .vtt text file. Additionally, when you are reviewing your meeting video, you can display the transcription within the video, just like captions! For this, on the desktop app, click on the Recordings tab on the left-hand side of the screen and click on Cloud recordings. You can access all your meeting recordings here. Also, enable Audio Transcript in the Cloud Recordings menu and save changes.



SKYPE

The best way to describe Skype would be 'oldie but goldie'. Since Microsoft took the helm of Skype, the number of changes over time haven't been very many. However, it still continues to be one of the most ubiquitous video calling solutions since many people have heard of it and it also works across several platforms.



BLUR THE BACKGROUND

While Skype doesn't possess the flair of Zoom's virtual backgrounds, it does have the ability to blur the background of the scene you're in. This can help since it makes the callers focus on you and less prone to being distracted by what's going on around you. However, this feature only exists in the desktop app for now. To activate this feature, simply hover your mouse on the red video button and then click on 'Blur my background'.



RECORD VIDEO CALLS

Skype can also record video calls, however, the recorded files are saved on your device and not on the cloud. Nevertheless, this is useful to log everything that happens during a meeting, help someone who missed the calls or even capture moments with your friends and family. The app also alerts everyone on the call when the recording begins, so you don't catch anyone off guard. To begin a recording on Skype, simply tap the three dots or the plus button on the bottom left corner and then click on Start Recording.



TRANSLATE IN REAL-TIME AND USE CALL SUBTITLES

Skype comes equipped with a pretty powerful Translator service that can translate everything you say or type in real-time for the person you're conversing with. Text can be translated to more than 60 languages while the voice translator is available for about 10 languages including English, Spanish, French, German, Mandarin, Portuguese, Italian, Arabic, and Russian. To enable this,